

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

LOGICAL POSITIVISM - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 07

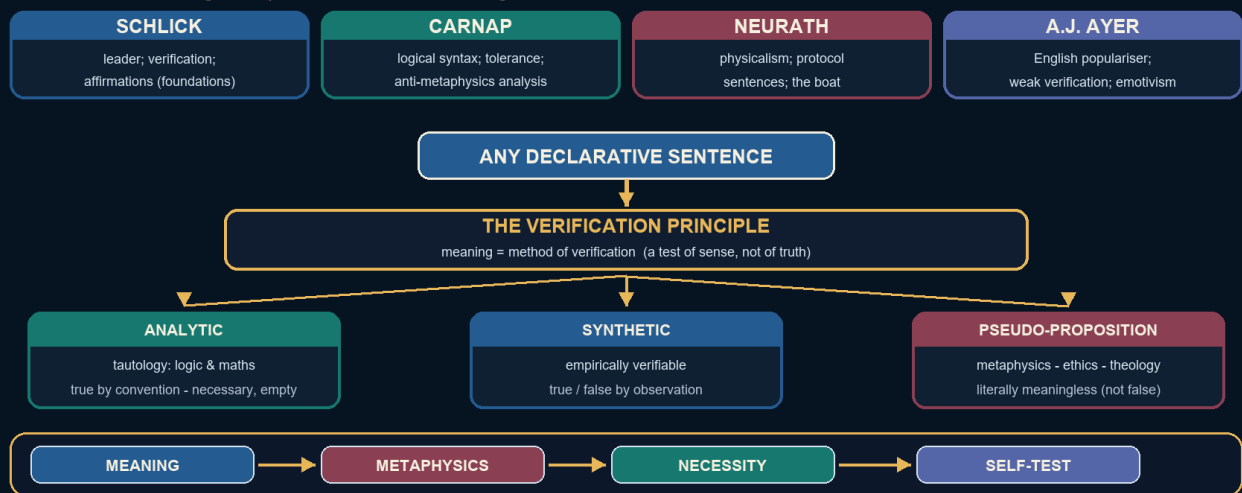
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PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | WESTERN PHILOSOPHY 07

LOGICAL POSITIVISM

The Vienna Circle's verification principle: fixing meaning, expelling metaphysics, reducing necessity to language.

THE VIENNA CIRCLE - logical empiricism armed with modern logic



One weapon, three targets: verify meaning, reject metaphysics, make necessity linguistic - then ask whether the principle survives its own test. Owns 7 of 112 Western PYQ parts, 2018-2025.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

LOGICAL POSITIVISM - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper I Western Philosophy 07

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 7 clause-owned questions, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2022 is the only year without one.
- Quine, Popper and early/late Wittgenstein parts are owned by their own clauses and are used here only as labelled comparisons, never counted among the 7.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: claim -> named text/quotation -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict.
- MCQs: 32 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation ten times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage is not forced: no verified 2026 news anchor exists, so none is invented; the standing relevance is the clause's permanent place in the philosophy of science and language.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the seven exact verified PYQs -> 32 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED TEXT/EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 7 VERIFIED CLAUSE-OWNED QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Logical Positivism owns exactly 7 primary parts, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2022 is the only year without one. Quine, Popper and early or later Wittgenstein questions are used only as labelled comparisons and are never counted here.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: How do the logical positivists show that metaphysical sentences are meaningless? Can their verification theory of meaning account for the meaningfulness of all scientific sentences? Discuss.

Model solution

Directive & demand. Two joined tasks: (i) *how* the positivists show metaphysical sentences meaningless, and (ii) *whether* their criterion can certify the meaningfulness of **all** scientific sentences. The marked half is (ii); a strong answer concedes the criterion works cleanly against metaphysics yet strains against science.

Thesis. The positivists show metaphysics meaningless by applying the verification principle as a criterion of *cognitive meaning*; but the very move that saves universal scientific laws (retreat to weak/indirect verification) is what makes the exclusion of metaphysics unstable - so the criterion cannot, without ad hoc repair, cover *all* scientific sentences while still barring metaphysics.

How metaphysics is shown meaningless. A non-analytic sentence is cognitively meaningful only if some possible observation is relevant to its truth or falsity (Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, 1936). Sentences such as Bradley's "The Absolute enters into evolution and progress" or Heidegger's "The Nothing itself nothings" are neither analytic nor empirically testable; they are **pseudo-propositions** - grammatically well formed, cognitively empty, not even false. Carnap (1932) adds the diagnostic: surface grammar mimics fact-stating language while logical analysis exposes an absent or malformed content.

Can it cover all scientific sentences? Singular observation reports pass easily. But the heart of science is *universal law* ("all copper conducts electricity"), which no finite set of observations can conclusively verify. **Strong** (conclusive) verification would therefore render science itself meaningless. The positivists retreat to **weak** verification (relevant observations render a law probable) plus *indirect* verification (law + initial conditions entail testable predictions) and the *in-principle / in-practice* distinction.

Objection / reply. The retreat overshoots: Church (1949) proved the weak criterion so permissive that arbitrary sentences - including metaphysics - qualify as "verifiable," collapsing demarcation. So the criterion is either too strong (kills science) or too weak (readmits metaphysics).

Verdict. The theory demarcates metaphysics from *singular* empirical claims decisively, but cannot certify *all* scientific sentences (universal laws) without a liberalisation that lets metaphysics back in. That internal instability - not any external attack - is why the programme fails; Popper's falsifiability and Quine's holism are later readings of the same gap.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: How do the logical positivists account for the meaning of general statements? Can the same account be applied to metaphysical statements? Discuss.

Model solution

Directive & demand. Expound the positivist account of the meaning of **general (universal) statements**, then test whether the *same* account transfers to metaphysical statements. The examiner rewards a precise mechanism (weak/indirect verification) and a sharp reason why metaphysics is *not* rescued by it.

Thesis. General statements are meaningful through *weak / indirect* verification - they have testable observational consequences even though no finite evidence conclusively proves them; metaphysical statements have **no** observational consequences at all, so the very feature that saves general statements is absent, and the account cannot be transferred.

Meaning of general statements. "All swans are white" and scientific laws range over past, future and unobserved instances, so they are never conclusively verifiable. The positivist responses: (a) Schlick treats an unrestricted law less as a complete proposition than as a *rule / instruction* for forming and checking predictions; (b) Ayer treats it as meaningful in the **weak** sense - some observations count for or against it. Either way meaning is secured by **confirmation through testable consequences** (indirect verification: law + initial conditions entail observation statements), not by proof.

Can the account apply to metaphysics? The criterion demands that *some* observation be relevant to truth or falsity. "Reality is the Absolute" or "das Nichts nichtet" yield no observational consequence - no experience would confirm or disconfirm them. Hence the testability that certifies general statements simply has no purchase on metaphysics; the two are not on a par.

Complication / critical edge. The transfer is blocked, yet the account of general statements is itself unstable: the weak sense that saves laws is, by Church's 1949 result, liberal enough to readmit metaphysics, and the strong/weak dilemma looms (strong kills laws, weak readmits metaphysics). So the positivist can bar metaphysics *only* by keeping verification strict enough - which then threatens the generality of science.

Verdict. General statements are meaningful via weak/indirect verification and confirmation; metaphysics cannot borrow this because it has no observational cash-value - but the same liberalisation that rescues science endangers the exclusion of metaphysics, exposing the criterion's core instability.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: "The Soul of Superman is Good." Critically examine the above statement in the light of logical positivism.

Model solution

Directive & demand. "Critically examine" a *specific sentence* - "The Soul of Superman is Good" - through logical positivism. The mark lies in showing the sentence is defective on **two** counts (metaphysical subject-term + emotive predicate), not merely asserting it is "meaningless."

Diagnosis. "Soul" has no empirical criterion of application (no observation individuates a soul), and "Superman" is a fictional/non-existent subject; "is Good" is an evaluative predicate. So the sentence fails the verification criterion twice over.

Emotivism on the predicate. For Ayer, ethical terms are not descriptive. "X is good" does not state a fact and has no truth-value; it *expresses* (evinces) the speaker's approval and tends to evoke it in others - emotive meaning, not cognitive meaning. Crucially it *expresses* rather than *reports* feeling: a report of one's feelings would be a verifiable psychological statement, which Ayer denies ethics is. Stevenson sharpens the point: such language works *dynamically* to influence attitudes (persuasive definition, disagreement in attitude).

Verdict. On both counts the sentence is a **pseudo-proposition**: the metaphysical subject-term voids reference, and the emotive predicate asserts nothing truth-apt. It expresses an attitude; it states no fact and is therefore cognitively meaningless though emotively significant. (One may note in a clause that the Frege-Geach embedding problem later pressures emotivism - but for the positivist the verdict on this sentence is settled: meaningless as fact, expressive as feeling.)

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 Q2(b), 15 marks

Question: What according to Logical Positivists are "pseudostatements"? How does one identify "pseudostatements"? Critically discuss with examples.

Model solution

Directive & demand. Define "pseudostatements," give the *identification test*, and "critically discuss with examples." The examiner wants Carnap's two generative mechanisms and a critical turn (self-refutation / provenance), not a bare definition.

Definition. A **pseudostatement** (Carnap, "Overcoming Metaphysics through Logical Analysis of Language," 1932) is a string with the *grammatical form* of an assertion but no cognitive meaning - no truth-conditions and no truth-value. It looks like a statement yet asserts nothing.

Identification test. Apply the criterion of cognitive meaning. A genuine statement is either (a) **analytic / contradictory** (true or false by meaning alone) or (b) **empirically verifiable** (some possible observation is relevant to its truth). Fail both and the string is a pseudostatement.

Two ways they arise (Carnap). (1) A word with *no criterion of application* - e.g., the metaphysical use of "the Absolute," "Being," "the transcendent"; the word is never tied to observable conditions. (2) Words individually meaningful but combined so as to *violate logical syntax* - Carnap's showpiece is Heidegger's "Das Nichts nichtet" ("The Nothing itself nothings"), which treats "nothing" (a logical quantifier) as a naming subject and invents the verb "to noth." Surface grammar mirrors "The rain rains"; logical grammar shows the sentence is ill formed.

Examples. "The Absolute is perfect," "Reality is spiritual," and many theological / value claims.

Critical discussion. The notion is only as secure as the verification criterion it presupposes - and that criterion is itself neither analytic nor empirically verifiable, inviting the **self-refutation** charge that the criterion is a pseudostatement by its own test. Ayer's reply: read the principle as a *definition / methodological recommendation*, not a factual claim. Heidegger could reply that the "violation" is deliberate, disclosing *das Nichts* in the mood of *Angst*. And Quine later attacks the analytic/synthetic line the test relies on. **Provenance:** render Carnap's target as "Nothing noths" / "the nothing nothings," never "nothing noughts."

Verdict. Pseudostatements are grammatically well-formed but cognitively empty sentences, identified by failing the analytic-or-verifiable test; a powerful anti-metaphysical instrument whose force depends on a criterion that struggles to certify itself.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: Does the rejection of metaphysics as proposed by Logical Positivists relate to problem of meaning or problem of knowledge or nature of things or all of them together? Discuss with suitable examples.

Model solution

Directive & demand. Decide whether the positivist rejection of metaphysics is a problem of **meaning**, of **knowledge**, of the **nature of things**, or **all together** - "with suitable examples." This is the signature discriminating question; the mark is won by ranking *meaning* as primary while acknowledging entanglement.

Thesis. The *distinctive* positivist rejection is a thesis about **meaning**: metaphysical sentences are rejected not as false, not as unknowable, but as **cognitively meaningless**. Yet the meaning-thesis rests on an empiricist *epistemology* and carries anti-*ontological* consequences, so "all together" is defensible only if meaning is marked as primary.

Contrast of three rejections.

- *Problem of knowledge* (Hume, Kant): metaphysics oversteps the limits of possible experience; its claims are unwarranted or unknowable but remain *meaningful questions*.
- *Nature of things / ontology*: metaphysics is opposed by denying the entities it posits (e.g., denying the Absolute *exists*) - still a factual dispute with truth-values.
- *Problem of meaning* (positivism): the metaphysical sentence is not even a *candidate* for truth or falsity; it fails the criterion of cognitive meaning, so there is no question to be right or wrong about. This is the innovation that separates positivism from Hume and Kant.

Examples. Bradley's "The Absolute enters into evolution and progress" - no observation is relevant, so it is meaningless, not merely unknown. Heidegger's "The Nothing noths" - a grammatical illusion (Carnap, 1932). The realist/idealist dispute over "the Absolute" is, for Ayer, not a factual disagreement but an exchange of pseudo-propositions.

Why not purely semantic. The meaning-thesis *presupposes* an empiricist theory of knowledge (only experience confers factual content) and *yields* an anti-ontological upshot (no super-empirical reality can be *meaningfully* asserted). So knowledge and ontology are entangled - as ground and as consequence - but neither is the *distinctive* claim.

Verdict. Relate the rejection decisively to the **problem of meaning**; that is the positivist innovation. Grant that it is grounded in an empiricist epistemology and disowns super-empirical ontology, so "all of them together" is acceptable *only* with meaning marked primary - the discrimination the question is testing.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Is the sentence "All objects are either red or not red" meaningful in the same way as "This page is white" is, according to the logical positivists? Discuss with arguments.

Model solution

Directive & demand. Decide whether "All objects are either red or not red" is meaningful in the **same way** as "This page is white," "with arguments." The mark is the *kind* of meaningfulness: analytic (necessary, empty) versus synthetic (empirical, contentful).

Thesis. No. Both are meaningful, but in *different ways*: the first is **analytic** - a tautology true by logical form (an instance of excluded middle, "p or not-p"), verified by understanding the words, factually empty; the second is **synthetic / empirical** - contingent, a posteriori, verified by observation, carrying factual content.

The positivist bifurcation (Hume's fork, sharpened). Every cognitively meaningful statement is either (a) *analytic* - true or false solely by the meanings/conventions of its terms, necessary and a priori but saying nothing about the world - or (b) *synthetic* - factual, contingent, meaningful through empirical verifiability.

Application.

- "All objects are either red or not red" is true regardless of any object; you confirm it not by inspecting things but by grasping the logical form. It is a **tautology** - necessarily true, informationally empty about the world.

- "This page is white" could be false; its truth turns on what observation reveals. It is a

synthetic empirical report with factual content.

Linguistic theory of necessity. The first sentence's necessity is *linguistic* - it is necessary because analytic (true by meaning/convention), not because a special faculty perceives a synthetic a priori truth about objects (contra Kant). This blocks any inference from the sentence's necessity to a deep fact about the redness of things.

Critical edge. The whole answer leans on the analytic/synthetic distinction, which Quine's "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" later argues cannot be drawn non-circularly. Note this as a labelled successor-critique - but for the positivist the verdict is firm.

Verdict. Both are meaningful, yet *not* in the same way: the red/not-red sentence is an empty analytic tautology, "This page is white" a contentful synthetic report - certified by two different arms of the criterion of meaning.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Present an exposition of the verification theory of meaning as propounded by the logical positivists. In this context also differentiate between the "strong" and the "weak" sense of the word "verifiable".

Model solution

Directive & demand. Two tasks: an **exposition** of the verification theory of meaning, and a **differentiation** of the *strong* and *weak* senses of "verifiable." Award weight to both; the differentiation is the discriminating half.

Exposition. Developed by the Vienna Circle (Schlick, Carnap, Neurath) and popularised in English by Ayer (*Language, Truth and Logic*, 1936), the theory holds that the *meaning* of a synthetic proposition is its **method of verification**, and that a sentence is cognitively meaningful only if it is either **analytic** or **empirically verifiable**. It is a criterion of *meaning*, **not** of truth: it fixes whether a sentence makes a genuine factual claim, not whether that claim is true. Motivations: the *difference-argument* (a sentence that makes no possible observational difference has no cognitive content - modelled on Einstein's operational critique of absolute simultaneity), meaning-as-use, the *demarcation* of science from metaphysics, and the *unity of science*. Consequence: metaphysics, and (via emotivism) ethics and theology, are pseudo-propositions.

Strong versus weak verifiability (Ayer's own distinction).

- **Strong sense:** a proposition is verifiable iff its truth can be **conclusively established** in experience. Fatal problem: universal laws, and statements about the past and

other minds, can never be conclusively verified - the strong sense would make science and ordinary discourse meaningless. Arguably no categorical singular is absolutely conclusive either.

- **Weak sense:** a proposition is verifiable iff **some possible observations are relevant** to, or render **probable**, its truth or falsity. Ayer adopts this to save scientific laws and generalisations.

- **In principle vs in practice** rides on the weak sense: "there are mountains on the far side of the Moon" was verifiable *in principle* though not, when asserted, *in practice*.

Critical coda. The weak sense proved too liberal - Church (1949) showed it readmits almost any sentence, including metaphysics; the strong sense is too strict. This **strong/weak dilemma** is the theory's central instability.

Verdict. The theory ties meaning to method of verification as a demarcation criterion; the strong sense is too strong (kills science), the weak too weak (readmits metaphysics) - naming the fault-line the movement never closed.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-32 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 33-40 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 10 times.

MCQ 1

Which trio formed the core of the Vienna Circle that developed logical positivism?

A. Moritz Schlick, Rudolf Carnap and Otto Neurath B. A. J. Ayer, G. E. Moore and Bertrand Russell C. Ludwig Wittgenstein, Karl Popper and W. V. Quine D. Gottlob Frege, Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Schlick led the Circle with Carnap and Neurath central. Ayer only popularised it in English; Wittgenstein, Popper and Quine were associated critics or outsiders, not the core.

MCQ 2

In logical positivism, the verification principle is primarily a criterion of:

A. the truth of a proposition B. the cognitive (factual) meaningfulness of a proposition C. the moral worth of a statement D. the grammatical correctness of a sentence

Correct answer: B

Explanation: It is a criterion of meaning, not truth: it decides whether a sentence has cognitive content, not whether that content is true. A meaningful sentence may still be false.

MCQ 3

For the positivists, a metaphysical sentence such as 'The Absolute is perfect' is best described as:

A. true but unverifiable B. false and therefore rejected C. cognitively meaningless (a pseudo-proposition), neither true nor false D. analytic and hence necessarily true

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Metaphysics is rejected as meaningless, not false: it fails the criterion of cognitive meaning and so has no truth-value at all.

MCQ 4

The 'strong' sense of verifiability was abandoned by Ayer chiefly because:

A. it made metaphysical statements meaningful B. it required all statements to be analytic C. it conflicted with the principle of tolerance D. no universal scientific law could ever be conclusively verified, making science meaningless

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Conclusive (strong) verification cannot certify universal laws or statements about the past and other minds, so it would exclude science itself - hence the retreat to the weak sense.

MCQ 5

Under the 'weak' sense of verifiability, a proposition is meaningful if:

A. some possible observations are relevant to, or render probable, its truth or falsity B. its truth can be conclusively and finally established C. it can be deduced from a metaphysical first principle D. it is merely grammatically well formed

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Weak verification requires only that experience be relevant to the proposition or render it probable, not that it be conclusively proven.

MCQ 6

'There are mountains on the far side of the Moon' (asserted before space travel) was meaningful for the positivists because it was verifiable:

A. in the strong sense B. in principle, even if not in practice at the time C. only analytically D. by emotive expression

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The in-principle / in-practice distinction lets a currently untestable but conceivably observable claim count as meaningful.

MCQ 7

Alonzo Church's 1949 objection showed that Ayer's revised (weak) verification criterion:

A. was equivalent to Popper's falsifiability B. made all statements analytic C. was so permissive that almost any sentence, including metaphysics, could be made 'verifiable' D. proved the existence of synthetic a priori truths

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Church (1949) demonstrated that the formal criterion let arbitrary sentences qualify as verifiable, collapsing the demarcation the positivists wanted.

MCQ 8

The 'difference-argument' for the verification principle holds that:

A. every meaningful sentence must be a tautology B. meaning is only the emotive force of a word C. only mathematics is genuinely meaningful D. if two sentences make no possible difference to any observation, they do not differ in cognitive meaning

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Modelled on Einstein's operational critique of absolute simultaneity: a distinction that makes no observational difference is cognitively empty.

MCQ 9

Which pair best captures the positive motivations the positivists gave for the criterion?

A. demarcation of science from metaphysics, and the unity of science B. the reality of the Absolute, and moral realism C. the synthetic a priori, and rational intuition D. speculative theology, and cosmology

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Verification was meant to demarcate meaningful science from metaphysics and to underwrite a unified, empirically grounded science.

MCQ 10

The Circle drew on Wittgenstein's *Tractatus*, but the precise correction is that:

A. the *Tractatus* already stated the verification principle explicitly B. truth-conditions / bipolarity in the *Tractatus* are not identical to verification-conditions; the Circle added a step Wittgenstein did not take C. Wittgenstein chaired the Vienna Circle D. the *Tractatus* rejected all logic

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The *Tractatus* gave truth-conditions and bipolarity; equating meaning with a method of verification was the Circle's own move, not Wittgenstein's.

MCQ 11

Which statement about Wittgenstein's relation to the Vienna Circle is correct?

A. He was the founding chairman of the Circle B. He co-authored the Circle's manifesto C. He was never a member of the Circle, though some members read the *Tractatus* with him D. He wrote *Language, Truth and Logic*

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Wittgenstein was never a Circle member; *Language, Truth and Logic* was written by Ayer, not Wittgenstein.

MCQ 12

A key difference between the *Tractatus* and Vienna positivism concerns:

A. the use of truth-tables B. the rejection of tautologies C. the endorsement of the synthetic a priori D. Wittgenstein's treatment of ethics and the mystical as *showing* what cannot be said, which the positivists dismissed as merely emotive or meaningless

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The *Tractatus* reserved a place for the ethical and mystical as inexpressible; the positivists treated such talk as cognitively meaningless.

MCQ 13

The distinctive positivist rejection of metaphysics is grounded in a problem of:

A. meaning B. knowledge alone C. ontology alone D. ethics

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Unlike Hume and Kant, who cite the limits of knowledge, the positivists reject metaphysics as meaningless - a semantic verdict, which is their innovation.

MCQ 14

Carnap's analysis of Heidegger's 'Das Nichts nichtet' ('The Nothing noths') concludes that the sentence:

A. is a profound synthetic a priori truth B. is a pseudo-statement that misuses 'nothing' (a quantifier) as a name and coins an illicit verb C. is empirically verifiable in principle D. is analytically true

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Carnap (1932) diagnosed a violation of logical syntax: 'nothing' is a logical quantifier, not a subject, and 'to noth' is illicitly coined - surface grammar masking a malformation.

MCQ 15

For Carnap, metaphysical pseudo-statements typically arise because:

A. they are deliberately poetic B. they contain mathematical errors C. their surface grammatical form mimics genuine statements while their logical form is defective or empty D. they are always self-contradictory

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Metaphysics deceives by grammatical resemblance to fact-stating language; logical analysis reveals the absence of cognitive content.

MCQ 16

On Ayer's emotivism, 'Stealing is wrong' primarily:

A. reports the speaker's psychological state, and is thus verifiable B. describes a non-natural moral property C. is analytically true D. expresses (evinces) the speaker's disapproval and has no cognitive truth-value

Correct answer: D

Explanation: For Ayer ethical utterances *express* feeling rather than *report* it; they are not statements of fact and are neither true nor false.

MCQ 17

Ayer insists an emotive utterance *expresses* rather than *reports* feeling because, if it merely reported the speaker's feeling, it would:

A. become an empirically verifiable psychological statement, contrary to his view that ethics is non-cognitive B. be a tautology C. be a metaphysical pseudo-statement D. be conclusively verifiable in the strong sense

Correct answer: A

Explanation: A report of one's feelings is a testable autobiographical fact; since Ayer denies ethics is factual, moral utterance must be expression, not report.

MCQ 18

Stevenson's development of emotivism emphasises 'disagreement in attitude', which means:

A. two people disagree about an empirical fact B. two people share the facts yet hold opposed favour/disfavour attitudes, which moral language works to influence C. two people disagree about the rules of logic D. moral terms are strictly analytic

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Stevenson distinguishes disagreement in belief from disagreement in attitude; ethical language functions dynamically (persuasive definition) to alter attitudes.

MCQ 19

The Frege-Geach problem presses emotivism by pointing out that:

A. moral terms are always verifiable B. emotivism entails moral realism C. moral sentences occur *unasserted* in embedded contexts (e.g., a conditional's antecedent), where no attitude is expressed, yet keep the same meaning D. Ayer and Stevenson agreed on everything

Correct answer: C

Explanation: If 'X is wrong' merely expresses an attitude, its occurrence in 'If X is wrong, then Y' - where nothing is expressed - is hard to explain; this is the embedding / Frege-Geach pressure.

MCQ 20

The 'linguistic theory of necessary propositions' holds that necessary truths are necessary because they are:

A. known by rational intuition of the world B. verified by repeated observation C. synthetic a priori D. analytic - true solely in virtue of the meanings / conventions of their terms

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Positivists explain necessity linguistically: necessary truths are analytic tautologies, true by meaning and empty of factual content.

MCQ 21

A central positivist claim about Kant is that:

A. there is no synthetic a priori knowledge; whatever is a priori is analytic and factually empty B. all mathematics is synthetic a posteriori C. space and time are metaphysical substances D. moral judgments are synthetic a priori truths

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Against Kant the positivists deny the synthetic a priori: the a priori is analytic (empty of factual content), the factual is a posteriori.

MCQ 22

'All objects are either red or not red' differs from 'This page is white' in that the former is:

A. synthetic while the latter is analytic B. analytic / tautologous (true by logical form) while the latter is synthetic and empirical (verified by observation) C. meaningless while the latter is meaningful D. verifiable in the strong sense while the latter is not

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The first is an instance of excluded middle, true by form and factually empty; the second is a contingent empirical report - meaningful in different ways.

MCQ 23

For the positivists, universal scientific laws are meaningful because they are:

A. conclusively verifiable by a finite number of observations B. analytic tautologies C. indirectly testable - their observational consequences can confirm or disconfirm them (weak verification) D. emotive expressions of the scientist's attitude

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Universal laws cannot be conclusively verified but are meaningful through testable consequences; this indirect / weak account raises the problem of confirmation.

MCQ 24

The 'protocol-sentence debate' within logical positivism concerned:

A. whether ethics is emotive B. the wording of the Circle's manifesto C. whether Wittgenstein should join the Circle D. the nature and status of the basic observation statements on which empirical knowledge rests

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Protocol sentences are the elementary reports of observation; the debate was over their form, certainty and revisability.

MCQ 25

In the protocol-sentence debate, the opposition is best described as:

A. Schlick's foundationalism (secure observation reports) versus Neurath's coherentism / physicalism (all statements revisable) B. Ayer's realism versus Carnap's idealism C. Popper versus Quine D. Frege versus Geach

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Schlick sought a secure base in observational affirmations; Neurath rejected any incorrigible foundation, treating protocols as physicalist and revisable within a coherent system.

MCQ 26

Neurath's image of rebuilding a ship at sea, plank by plank, without ever dry-docking it, expresses:

- A. the strong verification principle B. anti-foundationalism - we revise our body of statements from within, with no absolutely secure starting point C. the emotive theory of ethics D. the synthetic a priori

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The boat simile rejects an indubitable foundation: knowledge is repaired holistically from within, prefiguring theory-ladenness and holism.

MCQ 27

Carnap's Principle of Tolerance ('In logic, there are no morals') states that:

- A. all moral claims are meaningful B. there is one uniquely correct logical language C. everyone is free to choose their own logical syntax / language framework, judged by convenience rather than correctness D. metaphysics is true within a framework

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Tolerance makes the choice of a logical / linguistic framework conventional and pragmatic: there is no 'immoral' logic, only more or less useful ones.

MCQ 28

Carnap's distinction between 'internal' and 'external' questions holds that questions about the existence of entities (numbers, things) are:

- A. always metaphysical and meaningful B. answerable only by strong verification C. emotive expressions D. answerable *internally* within a chosen framework, whereas the *external* question of the framework's own reality is a practical choice, not a factual claim

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Internal questions have answers by the framework's rules; the external 'do numbers really exist?' is, for Carnap, a pseudo-question or a practical decision to adopt the framework.

MCQ 29

A common criticism of Carnap's Principle of Tolerance is that it:

- A. risks a conventionalism / relativism in which framework choice looks arbitrary and truth becomes framework-relative B. reintroduces the synthetic a priori C. proves the existence of the Absolute D. makes ethics cognitively meaningful

Correct answer: A

Explanation: If frameworks are freely chosen, critics worry that standards of correctness become merely conventional, threatening objectivity.

MCQ 30

The self-refutation objection argues that the verification principle itself is:

- A. an analytic tautology and hence trivially true B. neither analytic nor empirically verifiable, so by its own standard it is cognitively meaningless C. a synthetic a posteriori discovery D. an emotive expression of approval

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The principle is not true by definition nor testable by observation, so it seems to fail its own criterion - the classic self-refutation charge.

MCQ 31

Popper's falsifiability criterion differs from the verification principle because Popper offered it as a criterion of:

- A. cognitive meaning B. moral rightness C. *demarcation* between science and non-science, explicitly NOT a criterion of meaning D. analytic truth

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Popper proposed falsifiability to demarcate science from non-science and denied it was a theory of meaning; metaphysics, for him, may be meaningful though unscientific.

MCQ 32

Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism' undermines logical positivism chiefly by:

- A. defending the synthetic a priori B. proving the verification principle C. endorsing emotivism D. attacking the analytic/synthetic distinction and reductionism, replacing them with confirmational holism

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Quine argues the analytic/synthetic boundary cannot be drawn non-circularly and that statements face experience only as a corporate body (holism), dissolving key positivist commitments.

Remedial MCQ 33

Common error to avoid: for the positivists, to call a metaphysical sentence 'meaningless' is to say that it is:

- A. not a candidate for truth or falsity at all - it lacks cognitive content B. false C. probably false but possibly true D. true only within a framework

Correct answer: A

Explanation: 'Meaningless' is stronger than 'false': a false sentence is meaningful, whereas a pseudo-proposition has no truth-value to be false.

Remedial MCQ 34

Which correction about Ayer is accurate?

- A. Ayer founded and chaired the Vienna Circle B. Ayer was the English populariser (*Language, Truth and Logic*, 1936); the Circle's core was Schlick, Carnap and Neurath in Vienna C. Ayer and Wittgenstein co-wrote the *Tractatus* D. Ayer rejected the verification principle from the start

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Ayer transmitted Vienna positivism to the English-speaking world but did not found the Circle; he initially championed verification.

Remedial MCQ 35

Which is the accurate 'ownership' caution for the exam?

- A. Wittgenstein's later 'meaning is use' is a positivist doctrine B. Quine was himself a logical positivist C. Later Wittgenstein and Quine are critics / successors, not positivists; their questions appear here only as labelled comparisons D. Popper's falsifiability is simply the verification principle renamed

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Later Wittgenstein, Quine and Popper are used as comparisons or critics; conflating them with positivism is an examiner-penalised error.

Remedial MCQ 36

The precise point of Carnap's 'Nothing noths' example is that:

A. the sentence is a deep truth about being B. the sentence is empirically false C. the sentence is analytically true D. 'nothing' is a logical quantifier illegitimately treated as a naming subject, producing a syntactic pseudo-statement

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The error is logico-syntactic - a quantifier used as a name plus an invented verb - so the sentence is not false but ill formed and meaningless.

Remedial MCQ 37

The 'strong/weak dilemma' facing the verification criterion is that:

A. the strong sense is too strict (it excludes scientific laws) while the weak sense is too liberal (it readmits metaphysics) B. both senses exclude mathematics C. both senses are equivalent to falsifiability D. the weak sense is analytic and the strong sense synthetic

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Too strict versus too permissive is the theory's core instability, dramatised by Church's 1949 result.

Remedial MCQ 38

Why is Ayer's emotivism NOT the same as ethical subjectivism?

A. Because it says moral claims are empirically verifiable B. Subjectivism makes 'X is wrong' a true-or-false *report* about the speaker's feelings; emotivism denies it states any fact - it merely *expresses* feeling C. Because emotivism affirms non-natural moral properties D. Because emotivism is a form of moral realism

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Subjectivism is cognitivist (moral claims are truth-apt reports of attitudes); emotivism is non-cognitivist (expression, no truth-value) - a distinction students often miss.

Remedial MCQ 39

Restating the core point: the verification principle tells us whether a sentence:

A. is true B. is morally acceptable C. has cognitive meaning (is a genuine factual claim), not whether it is true D. is grammatically correct

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Meaning versus truth is the most tested distinction: a meaningful sentence can be false, and the method of verification is what confers factual content.

Remedial MCQ 40

In the 2023-style question, the positivist rejection of metaphysics is best said to relate to the problem of:

A. knowledge, exactly as in Kant B. the nature of things (ontology) alone C. ethics D. meaning primarily - though it rests on an empiricist epistemology and carries anti-ontological consequences

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The distinctive thesis is semantic (meaninglessness), distinguishing positivism from Hume and Kant, while presupposing empiricism and disowning super-empirical ontology.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain, with one example each, the positivist distinction between a *pseudo-proposition* and a *false proposition*. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Thesis. For the positivists the two are radically different: a *false proposition* is cognitively meaningful but happens not to correspond to the facts, whereas a *pseudo-proposition* fails the criterion of cognitive meaning and so has **no truth-value at all**.

False proposition. "This page is black" (when the page is white) is verifiable: an observation is relevant, we check, and we find it false. It is meaningful precisely because it could be confirmed or disconfirmed.

Pseudo-proposition. "The Absolute is perfect" (or "The Nothing noths") admits no relevant observation and is neither analytic nor empirical; it has the grammar of a statement but no content - it is not even a candidate for falsity.

Payoff. Rejecting metaphysics as *meaningless* is more radical than rejecting it as false: it removes the *question* rather than answering it. (Note the self-referential worry: the criterion must itself avoid being a pseudo-proposition.)

Original Mains 2 - 15 marks

Question: 'The verification principle is either too strong or too weak.' Examine this dilemma and assess whether logical positivism can escape it. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. The dilemma is the movement's central instability, and none of the standard repairs escapes it without either surrendering science or readmitting metaphysics.

The dilemma. On the **strong** reading, a sentence is meaningful only if *conclusively* verifiable. But universal laws, and statements about the past and other minds, are never conclusively verified - so the strong sense makes science itself meaningless. On the **weak** reading (Ayer), a sentence is meaningful if some observations are *relevant* or make it *probable*. This saves laws, but is so permissive that, as **Church (1949)** showed formally, almost any sentence - metaphysics included - can be dressed up as "verifiable."

Attempted escapes. (i) The *in-principle* / *in-practice* distinction rescues currently untestable but conceivable claims - but does nothing about the permissiveness. (ii) *Indirect* verification of laws through testable consequences keeps science meaningful - but the same device lets metaphysical systems borrow observational consequences. (iii) Ayer's 1946 revised formulation tightens the wording - but Church's result targets exactly such repairs, and each patch looks *ad hoc*.

Assessment. The successors reroute rather than rescue: Popper shifts to *falsifiability* as a criterion of **demarcation**, **not meaning**; Quine's holism dissolves the analytic/synthetic base the criterion presupposes.

Verdict. Positivism cannot escape the dilemma while keeping its sharp meaning/meaninglessness dichotomy. Its enduring legacy is a research programme - confirmation theory, demarcation, holism - not a surviving criterion.

Original Mains 3 - 20 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the logical positivist claim that necessary truths are analytic and that there is no synthetic a priori knowledge. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. The linguistic theory of necessity elegantly demystifies necessary truth and blocks rationalist metaphysics, but the analytic/synthetic distinction it rests on is fragile, so the bold denial of the synthetic a priori is powerful yet not decisively established.

The positivist claim. Necessity is *analyticity*: a necessary truth is true solely by the meanings / conventions of its terms - a tautology, a priori but factually empty. This is set squarely against Kant's *synthetic a priori* (arithmetic, geometry, the causal principle).

Arguments for it. (i) An empiricist bar: if a truth were both factual (synthetic) and knowable independently of experience (a priori), it would violate the principle that only experience confers factual content. (ii) Mathematics is re-read as analytic (logician / conventionalist), not a body of synthetic a priori insight. (iii) The apparent necessity of "all objects are either red or not red" is *logical form*, not a discovery about objects - so no synthetic a priori is needed to explain it.

Objections. (a) Quine's "Two Dogmas of Empiricism": the analytic/synthetic distinction cannot be drawn non-circularly (synonymy, definition and analyticity chase one another), so "necessary = analytic" loses its ground. (b) A regress worry: deriving the tautologies from "conventions" already presupposes logical inference, so convention cannot be the whole story of logical necessity.

Verdict. The theory rightly deflates rationalist appeals to a special faculty and shifts the burden onto defenders of the synthetic a priori; but because its analytic/synthetic pillar is contestable (Quine), the denial of synthetic a priori knowledge stands as a strong programme rather than a closed proof.